

Automation and AI

Automation and artificial intelligence (AI) are radically changing how organisations and their employees operate, with tools designed to help companies improve their processes, ways of working – and ultimately, their productivity and profitability. Indeed, according to a 2024 survey by consulting firm McKinsey & Company, 78% of organisations now use AI in at least one business function, up from 55% in 2023.¹ Here are some of the areas that are being impacted by automation and AI.

Communication

First, in the area of business communication, AI is being integrated into email software to automatically draft emails and responses based on past interactions – as well as tailor them to an individual's communication style. AI assistants can also prioritise emails based on user preferences, schedule follow-ups, and automate inbox management. Similarly, AI-based tools for word processing save people time and improve the quality of their writing by identifying and correcting errors in real time, allowing them to communicate more effectively.

Presentations and spreadsheets

In presentation software, 'generative AI' is being used to help create polished slides with simple prompts from users by incorporating relevant content from their past documents. The term 'generative' refers to the technology's ability to create original content.²

Similarly, AI can be used in spreadsheets to quickly analyse trends and generate professional-looking data visualisations.

Collaboration

AI assistants in collaboration platforms can help teams to automate transcriptions and meeting summaries, identify action items for individuals, and automatically set deadlines based on conversations, with the aim of saving time and improving efficiency.

Elsewhere, people collaborating on projects can use project management tools with AI-driven automation to assign tasks, send reminders, and update project boards, without the need for manual intervention, which can help project teams to stay on track.

Decision-making

Organisations increasingly rely on AI as a means of enhancing the quality of their decision-making. Analytics platforms allow managers to automate complex data analysis processes by using machine

¹ McKinsey & Company (2025). The state of AI: How organizations are rewiring to capture value. Available at: <https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/quantumblack/our-insights/the-state-of-ai> [Accessed 16 May 2025]

² Stryker, C. and Scapicchio, M. (2024). What is generative AI? IBM. Available at: <https://www.ibm.com/think/topics/generative-ai> [Accessed 16 May 2025]

learning algorithms to interrogate large datasets, identify patterns in the data and predict trends – thereby helping to make well-informed decisions.

Customer relationship management (CRM)

Customer relationship management (CRM) platforms are also harnessing AI to improve customer engagement and sales predictions. For example, as well as being able to produce marketing materials and tailor personalised messaging to customers, AI can analyse historical data and trends and anticipate market shifts to improve sales forecasts. These insights allow organisations to change their approach if required.³

Remote and hybrid working

AI tools such as those mentioned that support communication and collaboration are helping to drive a revolution in remote and hybrid working – a 2023 survey of small and medium-sized businesses shows that 87% of employees are now either fully remote or work part of the time remotely.⁴

Other technologies – such as augmented and virtual reality – can support remote and hybrid working by allowing employees to collaborate in 3D environments for meeting or training purposes, for instance.⁵

Manager's role

Managers have a key part to play in enabling and developing their teams to get the most from these new technologies. Depending on the manager's specific role and responsibilities, this may involve working with team members to look for opportunities to make their work more efficient, for example, by streamlining processes and automating repetitive tasks.

At the same time, managers need to consider the potential negative, as well as positive, impacts of these technologies on team members. This is particularly important when it comes to diverse groups – for instance, ensuring accessibility for people with disabilities.

A challenge here is the understandable fear that AI will replace human jobs. However, by automating more mundane tasks, AI can 'free up' employees to focus on more impactful, interesting and rewarding work.

³ Kimla, N. (2024). How AI can maximize your CRM: The future of customer relationship management. Forbes Business Council. Available at: <https://www.forbes.com/councils/forbesbusinesscouncil/2024/07/11/how-ai-can-maximize-your-crm-the-future-of-customer-relationship-management/> [Accessed 16 May 2025]

⁴ DigitalOcean (2023). DigitalOcean Currents report finds that adoption of AI/ML, and investments in cybersecurity and multi-cloud strategies are on the rise at small businesses. Available at: <https://investors.digitalocean.com/news/news-details/2023/DigitalOcean-Currents-Report-Finds-That-Adoption-of-AI/ML-and-Investments-in-Cybersecurity-and-Multi-cloud-Strategies-Are-On-The-Rise-at-Small-Businesses/default.aspx> [Accessed 16 May 2025]

⁵ Nopanen, V. (2023). First impressions on the new Microsoft Teams on HoloLens 2. Future Work. Available at: <https://futurework.blog/2023/01/18/teams-hololens2/> [Accessed 16 May 2025]

It's vital that managers and their team members stay up to date on the latest developments in AI and other technologies and continuously upskill to ensure that their capabilities stay relevant. This might involve training on how to work alongside AI tools, and focusing on developing higher-level 'human' skills that can complement AI – such as critical thinking and decision-making. It might also include encouraging experimentation with technology and fostering a culture of shared learning.⁶

⁶ CIPD (N.D.). Automation, AI and technology. CIPD Viewpoints. Available at: <https://www.cipd.org/uk/views-and-insights/cipd-viewpoint/automation-ai-technology/> [Accessed 16 May 2025]